

Responding to Job Interview Questions

Prepare for interview questions by putting thought into why the employer has asked the question and what they are looking for in your response. Below are interview questions with guidelines and a suggested response. Practice responding to questions you think you may be asked using the guidelines as a focus. (Also watch the “Performing Well in Job Interviews” video to observe these questions and answers in action.)

Question: Tell me about yourself

(Guidelines)

- Talk about what you've done to prepare yourself to be the best candidate for the position.
- Discuss skills and personal qualities you can bring to the position/organisation.
- Describe yourself positively and focus the interview on your strengths.
- Offer a summary of your personality, academic background and work history. Use examples to support your background and experience.
- Highlight accomplishments/ achievements or challenges you've faced.
- • ‘Tell me about yourself’ does not mean tell me everything. Talk about yourself in terms of your skills and the job

(Response)

I've spent the last three years studying a Bachelor of Communication Studies at AUT with a major in journalism. Group and written projects plus helping customers at work has developed my oral and written communication skills, and enhanced my understanding of other cultures. I have a real interest in keeping up to date with current affairs and heightened awareness of what people are interested in. I am good at juggling quite a few commitments, like study, work and other interests. Sometimes I take on too much, but I like keeping busy, and I don't get too overwhelmed because one of my strengths is good time management. I enjoy connecting with people and like to be part of a strong team.

Question: Tell me about a time when you have led others and what approach you took.

(Guidelines)

- This is a behavioural or situational interview question which is simply a question that asks you to give a real life example as evidence of a skill, knowledge or experience. Read “Behavioural/Situational Interview Questions” for more information.
- Employers ask behavioural questions to gather evidence that you have the skills they need. Examining your present and past performance in similar situations can also predict how you would perform in the future.
- Identify key skills that the employer is looking for from the job description, website, prospectus, brochures and think of examples that describe situations where you have demonstrated these skills.
- The STAR technique is helpful in putting together your response – for more information go to http://quintcareers.com/STAR_interviewing.html
- • Remember there are no right or wrong answers.

(Response)

I was the Editor of a newspaper my third year journalism class produced as part of the course. As Editor, I oversaw the production of the paper, which taught me the skill of multitasking. I had to make sure everyone met their deadlines, and since the paper couldn't go to print unless everyone had finished their stories, I learnt about accountability and how to motivate others. I was also writing news articles at the same time, so I improved my own news-gathering skills immensely. I remained positive around the others, the newspaper was released on time and we received excellent feedback on the articles.

Question: So you've studied journalism. Tell me about that.

(Guidelines)

- Name some of the key skills you gained through study (specific and transferable) and give evidence of how you put them into practice.
- Highlight what you are good at, interested in, or passionate about.

(Response)

I gained many specific skills. I practiced reporting writing skills for interviewing people, writing articles and presenting news stories. The presentation, research and computer skills I learned are all valuable to journalism. In general, I learnt how to work under pressure and meet deadlines and how to motivate myself since journalism students have to source their own stories. I find this really exciting. I learnt how to work in a team through group assignments, so I can work in a newsroom with colleagues as well as deal with people in the field.

Question: Tell me about your long-term career goals

(Guidelines)

- Look at the organisation's goals and how you will help work towards these through professional development.
- Describe goals that prove you will be an asset and not someone who wants to use the job as a short term stepping stone to greater roles.
- If there is a shortfall of your skills to the position, they will want you to explain how you will prepare to achieve these goals.
- Present this job as a significant part of your plan. Be ambitious but realistic.

(Response)

I'd like to eventually become a news producer because a news producer decides what gets broadcast during the news bulletin. This is a huge responsibility I'd enjoy. The skills most needed for this role include people management, problem solving, multi-tasking, organisation and planning. From my work as a journalist, I have started to acquire these skills and the skill of judging a good, worthwhile news story. But no matter what I end up doing, I always want to be able to do my best

Question: Why do you want to work for our organisation?

(Guidelines)

- Discuss that you are suited to their organisation and you have matched yourself well to them.
- Determine if you are really interested in working for them, or are you just looking for a job.
- Give examples which prove that you have matched yourself to the background and philosophy of the organisation. Tell them exactly what you like about them, the job, the services etc

(Response)

I believe in your focus for prime news and in particular I believe that people have a right to know if there has been an injustice in our society. Through journalism, I hope to make people more aware of these injustices when they occur. I've always admired the work of your reporters in bringing the public topical issues each day. From my research into this job and your organisation, I know that I would be creating news items which will be viewed by half a million people, and that really excites me. I know that journalists have to be intelligent, determined and quick-thinking, and my referees will tell you that I have all these qualities.